A–Z

The English Alphabet

English has 26 letters and about 40 sounds. This lesson shows how they work.

Introduction

1 26 letters

Aa	Bb	Cc	Dd	Ee	Ff	Gg	Hh	Ii	Jj	Kk	Ll	Mm
Nn	Oo	Pp	Qq	Rr	Ss	Tt	Uu	Vv	Ww	Xx	Yy	Zz

Vowels (5): A E I O U **Consonants (21):** all the other letters

Y is a consonant, but sometimes it sounds like a vowel. **my · happy**

2 A letter has a name and a sound

We say the **name** when we spell a word. We say the **sound** when we read.

	NAME	SOUND	AS IN
B	/biː/	/b/	bag
M	/em/	/m/	map
S	/es/	/s/	sun

3 More sounds than letters

English has **26 letters** but about **40 sounds**. So one letter can have more than one sound, and two letters can work together to make one sound. You will learn them step by step.

The English Alphabet (continued)

4 Sound symbols

A sound symbol shows how we **say** a sound, not how we write it. We write it between two lines.

/æ/ the sound of A in cat

/iː/ the mark ː means a long sound

5 How to read this book

cat	Orange letters are the letters we are learning.
make	Grey letters are silent. We do not say them.
● ALWAYS	The rule never changes.
● USUALLY TRUE	The rule has a few exceptions.
● NOT FIXED — LEARN EACH WORD	There is no rule. Learn each word.

Letters learned A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

Aa

The Letter A

A is the first letter of the alphabet. It is a vowel with four main sounds.

Vowel · 4 sounds

1 The sounds of A

/æ/
Short A

cat
map
bag

/eɪ/
Long A — it says its name

baby
paper
radio

/ɑː/
Open A — open your mouth

want
wash
pasta

/ə/
Weak A — a soft, short sound

about
again
sofa

2 When is A silent?

A is almost never silent on its own.

Letters learned A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

Ee The Letter E

E is the most common letter in English. It has three main sounds.

Vowel · 3 sounds

1 The sounds of E

/e/
Short E

bed
pen
ten

/iː/
Long E — it says its name

me
we
even

/ə/
Weak E — a soft, short sound

open
problem
moment

2 When is E silent?

At the end of a word, E is usually silent.
It often helps the vowel before it say its name.

make home time

Grey letter = silent

● USUALLY TRUE

Short words with only one vowel say the E:
me · we · be

3 E with other letters

ee /iː/ see tree green — ● ALMOST ALWAYS

ea /iː/ tea sea eat
/e/ bread head — ● NOT FIXED — LEARN EACH WORD

Letters learned A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

The Letter I

I is a vowel. It has four main sounds.

Vowel · 4 sounds

1 The sounds of I

/ɪ/
Short I

sit
pin
big

/aɪ/
Long I — it says its name

hi
kind
tiger

/iː/
Like long E — in words from other languages

ski
pizza
visa

/ə/
Weak I — a soft, short sound

pencil
animal
family

2 When is I silent?

I is almost never silent on its own.

3 I with other letters

ai — /eɪ/ rain wait paint — USUALLY TRUE

A few words are different: said · again

ie — /iː/ field chief brief; /aɪ/ pie tie — NOT FIXED — LEARN EACH WORD

Letters learned A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z



The Letter O

O is a vowel. It has five main sounds.

Vowel · 5 sounds

1 The sounds of O

/ɑː/
Short O — American English

hot
box
stop

/oʊ/
Long O — it says its name

go
no
hotel

/ʌ/
Like the U in "cup"

money
month
front

/uː/
A long "oo" sound

do
to
into

/ə/
Weak O — a soft, short sound

today
lemon
second

2 When is O silent?

O is silent in a few words.

people leopard

Grey letter = silent

● NOT A RULE — A FEW WORDS

The Letter O (continued)

3 O with other letters

oa	/oʊ/	boat	coat	road	● ALMOST ALWAYS
oi	/ɔɪ/	oil	coin	boil	● ALMOST ALWAYS
oo	/uː/	food	moon	too	● NOT FIXED — LEARN EACH WORD
	/ʊ/	book	good	look	

Letters learned A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z



The Letter U

U is the last of the five vowels. It has five main sounds.

Vowel · 5 sounds

1 The sounds of U

/ʌ/
Short U

cup
bus
sun

/juː/
Long U — it says its name

music
menu
unit

/uː/
A long "oo" sound

flu
super
truth

/ʊ/
A short "oo" sound

put
push
full

/ə/
Weak U — a soft, short sound

focus
minus
album

2 When is U silent?

U is almost never silent on its own.

The Letter U (continued)

3 U with other letters

au

/ɑː/ **Au**gust **au**thor l**au**ndry

A few words are different: laugh

● USUALLY TRUE

ou

/aʊ/ **ou**t l**ou**d cl**ou**d

/uː/ y**ou** s**ou**p gr**ou**p

/ʌ/ c**ou**ntry y**ou**ng t**ou**ch

● NOT FIXED — LEARN EACH WORD

ue

/uː/ bl**ue** tr**ue** gl**ue**

● ALMOST ALWAYS

ui

/uː/ fr**ui**t s**ui**t

Other words are different: build · guide

● NOT FIXED — LEARN EACH WORD